

Rain Delays Rebs' Debut, but Can't Cool Baseball Fever

By LARRY FOX

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MONTGOMERY, July 20 — The hard-luck franchise of the Southern Association took it on the chin again Friday night.

With over 3,000 tickets already sold and enthusiasm at a pennant pitch, Montgomery's Southern debut with New Orleans was rained out. Rebel boosters only hope that the momentum of their big campaign to provide an enthusiastic greeting for the old Little Rock Travelers will carry through until Saturday's double-header.

A heavy shower hit the wandering Travelers' new home just about an hour before game time and, when it showed no sign of abating, the "rained out" sign was displayed at Pat-

erson Field.

All regular reserved seats had been sold for the Rebels' home opener and a capacity crowd of near 6,000 was expected. Actually, the club had been without a home for about a week, having been on the road since officially moving out of Little Rock.

Signs reading "Let's all go to the ball game" had been plastered all through the downtown area and a high-powered campaign by Karl Reed's Chamber of Commerce committee had the citizenry more excited over this recent baseball development than when Montgomery first joined the Sally League in 1951. And it was a far cry from the apathy that forced this city's Sally League entry to move to Knox-

ville earlier this year.

How well Montgomery reacts to AA ball will determine if the club stays here next year. And if the folks turn out Saturday for the delayed welcome home, they will have gone a long ways to achieving that end.

THE CLIPBOARD: New Orleans manager Andy Cohen marvelled at the local enthusiasm and was especially overwhelmed when a local cab driver refused to charge his players for taking them out to the park. He plans to use **Ily Cohen** and either **Don Kildoe** or **Don Dangels** in the 6:30 p.m. (CST) double-header. . . . Montgomery's **Steve Souchock** will probably counter with **Van Fletcher** and **Bill Voiselle**. . . . Visitors who

checked in early for the opening included League President **Charlie Hurth**, his wife and daughter; **Owen Martinez**, general manager of Mobile, and Earl Mann, Atlanta owner.

Guiding force in bringing the Southern to Montgomery was **Ben Goldtsman**, a local businessman. He was responsible for Montgomery's previous association with the Sally League, but was not connected with the club this dismal season. . . . This marked the first visit to Montgomery for the charming Mrs. Hurth since the last time the city welcomed a Southern Association franchise in mid-season. That was 1943 when Chattanooga moved in for half a campaign. The opening-night foe on that occasion? These same New Orleans Pelicans. . . . Montgomery

solved the problem of transforming its uniforms at the last minute. Patches reading "Rebels" could not be found, but enough block "M"s were rounded up to replace the old "Travelers". . . . One reason Montgomery folk are more confident the Southern operation will be successful where the Sally enterprise failed: Beer was not allowed to be sold in the city-owned park the first half of the season. It will be allowed now.

Probably nowhere in the nation has more disappointment been registered over a rainout of a game between the seventh and eighth-place clubs than here. . . . Opening night ceremonies will be held over until Saturday. . . . **John P. Baird**, majority owner of the club, was over from Little Rock, of course.